



### Mitron app may be unsafe

Mitron, the Tik Tok alternative, has a vulnerability which could compromise user accounts. <https://digit.in/jun20-30>



### AI could detect wildfires

The European Space Agency's satellites can provide a secondary source for assessing wildfire risk. <https://digit.in/jun20-31>

# ANCIENT EXPLORERS

## The epic sea voyages of the past

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A Filipino double outrigger paraw, also known as a trimaran which is of Austronesian design

Credit: Göran Höglund

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he most celebrated explorers in history were also privateers who were cruel to the natives that they

came across. James Cook, Christopher Columbus, Francis Drake and Vasco da Gama are all glorified but were little more than agents of the imperialist machine. Thing is, in all the lands that they “discovered”, there were already natives who had gone there, and the ancient sea voyages of these journeys is where the real story of exploration is at.

### AUSTRONESIA

From 3000 BCE to about 1200 CE, seafaring people that originated from Taiwan spread across the Pacific. They are known as the Austronesian people, and they were the first culture to use seafaring technologies to settle on uninhabited islands. First they moved into Sumatra, Java and Borneo. Around 1500 BCE, they

sailed to the Solomon Islands and Fiji. After that, around 200 BCE the Micronesian islands of Kiribati, Chuuk and Guam were settled. They made the arduous trip across the Indian Ocean and landed in Madagascar around 500 CE. Finally, in 1200 CE, they landed in the remote Polynesian islands in the Pacific, and Hawaii. Today, the descendants of these people are spread out over half the planet from Madagascar to Easter Island, are the inhabitants of the remote Pacific islands, and are one of the most geographically widespread language groups in the world. If you are wondering about the inhabitants of some of the lands in between, Australia and New Guinea were populated by people who had crossed over by land or made short oceanic hops when the ocean levels were lower, beginning from 60,000 BCE. Before the colonial era, the Austronesians were the widest spread people with a common origin.

There were a number of maritime innovations that allowed these voyages to take place. A natural progression from making rafts by tying two logs together, was that of making catamarans by tying two canoes together. Then, the Austronesians started making one of the canoes much smaller than the other, developing the outrigger canoes. This innovation led to smaller canoes being attached on both sides of the larger canoe, leading to double outrigger canoes, or trimarans. These boats were steered using an oar on one side. The vessels were constructed using hollowed out logs, tied together with planks and with the joints sealed with pastes made of plant material that expanded when they got wet, making sure that that water could not seep in. Considering no nails were used, these were incredibly effective watercraft.

At the same time, the designs for the sails were continuously developed. The earliest were crab's claw